

Ben KAWAM

EMAIL: ben.kawam@gmail.com | WEBSITE: benkawam.github.io | GITHUB: github.com/BenKawam

APPOINTMENTS

APRIL 2026 - Present	Postdoctoral researcher Max Planck Institute of Animal Behavior, Germany
MAY 2025 - DEC 2025	Resident Fellow Konrad Lorenz Institute for Evolution and Cognition Research, Austria

EDUCATION

APR 2022 - DEC 2025	Ph.D. in Behavioural Ecology German Primate Center & University of Göttingen, Germany
SEPT 2019 - NOV 2021	M.Sc. Erasmus Mundus Master Programme in Evolutionary Biology University of Groningen, Netherlands; University of Montpellier, France
SEPT 2016 - JUN 2019	B.Sc. in Biology, focus on Organismal Biology and Ecology University of Namur, Belgium
JAN 2019 - JUN 2019	Exchange semester Uppsala University, Sweden

PUBLICATIONS

* indicates joint first authorship.

2025	Kawam, B. , McElreath R., Ostner, J., Redhead, D. & Schülke, O., (2025). Inferring the causes of animal social network structure from time-series data. <i>bioRxiv</i> .
2025	Redhead, D.*, Kawam, B.* , Young, J.-G., Franks, D., Philson, C. S., van Duijn, M., Hart, J., McElreath, M. B., McElreath, R., Power, E. A., Ross, C., Sosa, S., Steglich, C., Weiss, M., & Brent, L. J. N. (2025). Five misunderstandings in animal social network analysis. <i>EcoEvoRxiv</i> .
2024	Kawam, B. , Ostner, J., McElreath R., Schülke, O., & Redhead, D. (2025). A causal framework for animal social network structure. <i>PLOS Computational Biology</i> .
2020	Biwer, C.*, Kawam, B.* , Chapelle, V., & Silvestre, F. (2020). The role of stochasticity in the origin of epigenetic variation in animal populations. <i>Integrative and Comparative Biology</i> , 60(6), 1544-1557.

AWARDS AND HONOURS

2025	PhD: <i>Summa cum laude</i> (defence); <i>Magna cum laude</i> (dissertation).
2021	MSc: <i>Cum laude</i> . Best Presentation, 2021 PSGB Winter Meeting. Erasmus+ Traineeship Grant (5000 EUR), funded by the EU.
2019	BSc: <i>Summa cum laude</i> . Erasmus+ Mobility Grant (2000 EUR), funded by the EU.

TALKS AND WORKSHOPS

2026	Kawam, B., & Redhead, D. <i>Animal Social Network Analysis</i> (150 min). Pre-conference workshop. <i>EFP 2026, Montpellier, France.</i>
2026	The causal analysis of animal social networks. Invited speaker. <i>Centre for Research in Animal Behaviour, University of Exeter, Exeter, UK.</i>
2025	Invited speaker. <i>Department for the Ecology of Animal Societies, MPI-AB, Konstanz, Germany.</i>
2025	Kawam, B., McElreath R., Ostner, J., Redhead, D. & Schülke, O., <i>Inferring the causes of animal social network structure from time-series data.</i> Invited speaker. <i>Department of Sociology, University of Groningen, Netherlands.</i>
2024	Kawam, B., Ostner, J., McElreath R., Schülke, O., & Redhead, D. <i>A causal framework for animal social network structure.</i> Conference contribution. <i>EHBEA 2024, Montpellier, France.</i>
2023	Invited speaker. <i>Department of Sociology, University of Groningen, Netherlands.</i> Conference contribution. <i>Behaviour 2023, Bielefeld, Germany.</i>
2023	Kawam, B., Ostner, J., McElreath R., Schülke, O., & Redhead, D. <i>Personality and social relationships in animal social networks.</i> Colloquium. <i>BeCog summer colloquium, Göttingen, Germany.</i> Invited speaker at the <i>MARM group meeting, GELIFES, University of Groningen.</i>
2021	Kawam, B., Huchard, E., Cowlshaw, G., & Carter, A. J. <i>Health costs and benefits of social connectedness for wild baboons.</i> Conference contribution. <i>PSGB 2021 Winter meeting.</i>

TECHNICAL SKILLS

MODELING	Probabilistic and causal modeling.
PROGRAMMING	R, Stan, GitHub, HTML & CSS.
FIELDWORK	Sampling of behavioural, ecological, and spatial data; basic field management.
ILLUSTRATION	Adobe Illustrator, TikZ.
WRITING	LaTeX, Quarto/R Markdown, Microsoft Office.

TEACHING AND SUPERVISION

2025	<i>Introduction to Causal Inference and Directed Acyclic Graphs</i> (30-120 min talk). Lecturer for <i>Linear models and their application</i> , designed for graduate students & faculty.
2024	Workshop given to PhD students in Ecology and Psychology. Lecturer for <i>Linear models and their application</i> , designed for graduate students & faculty.
2023	Workshop given to PhD students in Ecology and Psychology.
2022	<i>Getting Started with GitHub</i> (30 min talk) Workshop given to PhD students in Ecology and Psychology. Supervision of a M.Sc. student, Lena Lindner, for a 10 weeks project.

REVIEWER EXPERIENCE

Scientific Journals

Biological Reviews

Methods in Ecology and Evolution

RELATED EXPERIENCE

MAR 2022 - Present	Web Designer at Evolutionary Biology Crash Course Co-responsible for Web Design, Graphic Design and Outreach.
2019 - Present	Scientific Illustrator Creation of scientific illustrations and logos. Examples here .
JUL 2018 - AUG 2018	Intern at Tacugama Chimpanzee Sanctuary, Sierra Leone Behavioural observations; animal care; logistic support; outreach.
JUL 2017 - AUG 2017	Intern at Cikananga Wildlife Sanctuary, Indonesia Behavioural observations; animal care; logistic support; outreach.
OCT 2015 - JAN 2016	Intern at Gibbon Rehabilitation Center, Thailand Outreach; animal care; gibbon tracking.

REFERENCES

Prof. Dr. Richard McElreath

Director

Department of Human Behaviour, Ecology & Culture, Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology
Deutscher Platz 6, 04103 Leipzig, Germany

Relationship to applicant: Co-supervisor of PhD thesis

Email: richard_mcelreath@eva.mpg.de

Phone: +49 (0)341 3550 315

Dr. Daniel J. Redhead

Assistant Professor in Sociology

Department of Sociology/ICS, University of Groningen
Grote Rozenstraat 31, 9712 TG Groningen, The Netherlands

Relationship to applicant: Co-supervisor of PhD thesis

Email: d.j.redhead@rug.nl

Phone: +31 (0)631985033

Dr. Brendan J. Barrett

Group Leader

Department for the Ecology of Animal Societies, Max Planck Institute of Animal Behavior
Büchlestraße 5, 78467 Konstanz, Germany

Relationship to applicant: Group leader

Email: bbarrett@ab.mpg.de

Phone: +49 7531 9450552

Dr. Oliver Schülke

Senior Scientist

Department for Behavioural Ecology, University of Göttingen
Kellnerweg 6, D-37077 Göttingen, Germany

Relationship to applicant: Co-supervisor of PhD thesis

Email: oliver.schuelke@biologie.uni-goettingen.de

Phone: +49 (0)551 3923 926